

Finding Job Postings

Estimated time needed: 5 minutes

Introduction

When you begin your job search, you will start looking at job listings. How will you decide where to send applications? When a listing catches your eye, you can evaluate whether you will be a strong candidate for the role with a good chance of getting the job.

Objectives

After completing this reading, you will be able to:

- Describe sections of a job listing
- Differentiate between full-time and contract job postings
- Describe contact info and preferences
- Describe job search warning flags

Job listing structure

A job listing can have several sections. Let's briefly review some key sections.

- The **Overview of the company and the role** section provides a broad description of the job position and hiring company.
- The **Responsibilities and Tasks** section outlines what the candidate can expect as their tasks and what they will be in charge of. It may also describe how the employee will function in the company and who they will work with.
- The **Requirements and qualifications** section describes what the company is looking for in a candidate, and it may include educational background, certifications, years of experience, and other hard and soft skills. Sort the required qualifications from the preferred ones and ensure you have all the required qualifications and at least 50% of the preferred ones. Don't hesitate to apply even if you are missing some requirements. Consider other skills or experience you possess that may compensate for the missing ones.

Differences between full-time and contract job postings

It's important to note whether a job is full-time (FTE) or contract (contingent or temporary). This refers to the worker's tax status, not their working hours. Many contractors work full-time hours. However, FTE and contract employees do not have the same working conditions and contractual terms of employment. Depending on your expectations, accepting an FTE position may be a better option than signing as a contract employee, but both have their benefits and drawbacks. Here are some basic differences between FTE and contract employees.

Full-Time Employee Positions	Contract Positions
Work can continue indefinitely (often after a probationary period)	Works for a length of time specified in the contract
Pay is often more regular (per hour or a monthly/yearly salary)	Receive payment for services by hourly pay or by deliverables requested, and an employer may not deduct taxes; the contractor is responsible for sending appropriate periodic tax payments
Must comply with different internal policies such as training and work procedures	May not receive training or only minimal training. Expected to begin work with needed skills
Entitled to receive company benefits and incentives	Generally does not receive company benefits or incentives. Note: This may be a benefit if you already have health care and a 401k (US) or pension through alternate sources
Usually has different legal rights regarding termination and labor practices (although this may not be true in some states)	May be terminated at will and without cause or notice

Contact information and preferences

If you decide to conduct a job search using a website, pay close attention to the instructions within each job posting you review. Companies each have preferences or policies regarding the job application process, and you can disqualify your application by not following them. Sometimes, it's as simple as uploading a saved resume and using an **Apply** button. These companies let an applicant tracking system (ATS) complete an automated initial scrutiny to filter qualified candidates.

Many companies use job-searching websites to get their job listings viewed by more potential candidates but then choose to have job seekers apply through their company websites. Usually, job candidates must fill out online forms and include supporting documents through the company's website only. Other employers provide an email address or telephone number in their job listings and have applicants contact a specific person or team to process their job application.

While most employers do not require a cover letter, some do. Some will also require a work sample, portfolio link, or applicants to answer screening questions or take skills assessments. The bottom line is ensuring you have read and understood how to submit a job application.

Job search warning flags

Employers generally review job applications and examine the candidate's qualifications to determine who is the best fit for their company. You can also determine whether a company is a good fit for you before you submit a job application. Consider the following "warning flags" if you see them.

- **Lack of clarity** in job title, role, or description: a job title in a listing that is too general or a description that does not provide a clear idea of what the position entails should raise concerns. It is very difficult to prepare a job application for a position with unclear or vague specifications.
- **Unnecessary jargon, acronyms, and other unclear language** should not appear in a job posting. The overuse of such language shows a lack of clear communication from the company to employees and potential applicants.
- **Unrealistic expectations** should make you think twice about whether a company has a good idea of what the job entails or whether they will exploit new hires and set them up for failure. An example might be a job requiring several years of experience for an entry-level position; another might require high-level function in too many unrelated areas of expertise.
- **Evident biases or prejudice** is another warning. A company that creates job listings that include any form of language that explicitly excludes or states a preference for a group of candidates based on personal traits should not be considered a potential employer. The bias may include race, religion, gender, age, and orientation, but also factors like marital status, nationality, parental status, military status, appearance, ability (unless it's directly related to the job description in some way), and others. In many cases, such job postings are against the law, and even if that isn't the case, it doesn't speak well of the company's ethics.

Conclusion

Every hiring company should aim to make a job posting clear and inviting, especially for qualified candidates. The screening, selection, interviewing, and hiring processes should be executed with intention and follow a transparent series of steps. A company's job listings are their chance to create a first impression, and they should be taken seriously. They can be your first indication about the culture and competence of that company. Be on the lookout for indications that landing a job with a particular company may not be in your best interest as a job seeker.



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